





ALL THAT SASS (Clockwise from far left) Raveena Tandon in *Aranyak*; shot from *Kaun Banegi Shikharwati*; Samantha Akkineni in *The Family Man*

two women at odds, in February. A leading production company is set to launch an OTT platform next year that will specialise in "female forward content". For Nimisha Pandey, chief content officer of ZEE5, it is "high time" that women get to dominate the narrative, given that they form a significant proportion of the OTT audience.

Ormax Media, a leading media analytics and consulting firm, estimates that women constitute 41 per cent of India's 353 million digital video audience, with the ratio of male to female viewers nearly equal in the big metros. Ormax CEO Shailesh Kapoor notes that while viewership for action and crime series tends to be male, romance and romcom genres draw a more balanced audience, with 45 per cent of viewership coming from women.

NOT JUST WONDER WOMEN



Almost every streaming platform has had a popular woman-centric show, be itSushmita Sen-led **AARYA** (left) or Netflix's **MASABA MASABA**

Women have always been the focus on television, with shows like *Rajini*, *Tara*, *Shanti*, *Tu Tu Main Main* and *Hum Paanch* attracting a huge viewership. The trend continues, with *Anupamaa* on Star Plus being the most-watched show currently. But the roles were restricted either to the *saas-bahu* stereotype or the traditionally-clad crusader. "For the longest time," says Rangita Nandy of British Nandy Communications Ltd, the production company behind *Four More Shots Please!*, "we were reduced to stereotypes or just add-ons to the male protagonists. It is only in the past five years that we are getting to paint women characters in different colours without chasing the holier-than-thou prototype we were stuck with for years." Not just that, heroes could do any wrong on television but still be romanticised. Women were strictly good or evil. "You never saw a flawed woman being loved rather than judged, before," says Pandey. Streaming narratives have liberated